

METROPOLITAN POLICE - CASE FILE

CASE NUMBER: AR-1891-029

Case Title: Arson at the Blackwood Estate Stables

Date of Incident: 21 June 1891

Date Report Filed: 22 June 1891

Investigating Officer: Inspector J. Hartley

Location: Blackwood Estate, Surrey

INCIDENT SUMMARY

Shortly after 02:00 on 21 June 1891, a fire broke out in the stable block of the Blackwood Estate. The estate's night watchman raised the alarm and the household assisted in extinguishing the blaze before it spread to the main house. Two horses were lost. The stable block was largely destroyed.

An empty oil can was recovered from the scene. The estate manager states that no oil can was kept in the stable. The fire is therefore treated as a case of arson.

WITNESS INTERVIEW 1

Witness: Mr. Crale, Night Watchman

Interviewed by: Inspector J. Hartley

Q: Where were you when the fire began?

A: I was on my round near the orchard, on the far side of the estate. I saw the glow above the stable roof and ran toward it. I should say it was a little after two o'clock.

Q: Did you see anyone near the stables?

A: As I came up the path I saw a man hurrying away from the stable yard toward the south gate. I called out but he did not stop. It was too dark to see his face.

Q: Could you tell anything of the man at all?

A: Only that he was tall and wore a long dark coat. I am sorry I cannot say more. The light was very poor.

WITNESS INTERVIEW 2

Witness: Mr. Doyle, Estate Manager

Interviewed by: Inspector J. Hartley

Q: Who had reason to wish the estate harm?

A: There is one man I must mention. A former groom, Tom Reeve, was dismissed by Lord Blackwood a fortnight ago for theft. He left in a great temper and was heard to swear he would see the estate suffer for it. I did not take it seriously at the time.

Q: Where is Tom Reeve now?

A: I do not know. He left his cottage on the estate the day he was dismissed and has not been seen here since.

Q: Was anything kept in the stable that might explain the fire?

A: Nothing of the sort. No oil, no lamp left burning. The lamps are taken to the tack room each night without fail.

EVIDENCE LOG

Item 1: One empty oil can, recovered from the stable yard. Not estate property.

Item 2: Bootprints near the south gate, leading away from the stables. A man's boot, large size.

Item 3: The south gate, found open. It is normally kept closed but is not locked at night.

NOTES

Inspector Hartley notes that the recovered oil can and the bootprints toward the south gate are consistent with the watchman's account of a man fleeing the scene. Tom Reeve, the dismissed groom, is to be located and questioned. No witness has yet placed Reeve at the estate on the night of the fire.

END OF CASE FILE AR-1891-029